

Communicating online

Software and the internet have opened many avenues for communication. People can now talk, send audio, text, and visual messages around the world in a matter of seconds, and receive instant replies.

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Instant messaging

A quick and easy way of communicating, instant messaging is a process of sending real-time text-based messages from one user to another. Using a shared software client, two or more people can send messages over a network, usually the internet or cellular. One of the most popular forms of online communication, it even allows users to create chat rooms, share links, and send photos and videos.



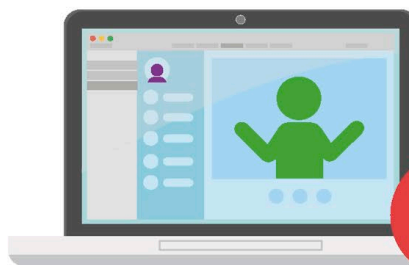
Users have to click "send" to deliver their messages.

◀ Messaging on a smartphone

Online chats are primarily the transmission of messages over a network. In some cases, users can even see the other person typing, and if they have received the previous messages.

Video chatting

This is a popular method of live interaction, using the internet for transmission and reception of audio-video signals. Video chats, or video calls, allow users to communicate with each other in real time. It can take place on a computer, tablet, or smartphone, and requires a webcam and a specific application, such as Skype or FaceTime.



▷ Using a webcam

Webcams are an input device that can be connected to the computer for streaming videos or taking pictures.



Emailing

Short for "electronic mail", emails are the digital equivalent of exchanging letters. They are text-based messages that can be sent or received by anyone with an email account. Users can create a unique email address from which messages can be sent back and forth. Emails can even include attachments, such as documents, images, and video. A sender can choose to "cc" (short for carbon or courtesy copy) an extra person or people into an email, or "bcc" them (blind carbon copy), which conceals the person's identity from other recipients.



◀ @ sign

Email addresses are recognizable by the "@" sign. The first part of an email is called the local part of the address. The part after the @ sign is usually a domain name that hosts the email program.

More than
205 billion emails
are sent every
day worldwide.